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Published in:
Geoforum

Publication status and date:
Published: 18/04/2021

DOI (link to publisher):
10.1016/j.geoforum.2021.04.001

Document Version
Publisher's PDF, also known as Version of record

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Citation for the published version (APA):
Ramos, C. (2021). The return of strongman rule in the Philippines: Neoliberal roots and developmental implications. *Geoforum*, *124*, 310-319. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.geoforum.2021.04.001

Link to publication on the EUR Research Information Portal

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Erasmus University Rotterdam
Making Minds Matter

Geoforum 124 (2021) 310–319

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Geoforum

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/geoforum

The return of strongman rule in the Philippines: Neoliberal roots and developmental implications

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Authoritarian-populism
Neo-illiberalism
Political economy of development
Development strategies
New right populist politics

ABSTRACT

The existing scholarship on the Philippines' strongman president and new right populist politician Rodrigo Duterte tends to emphasise the conjunctural conditions that led to his election and done little to explore the implications of his rule on the political economy of development in the Philippines. In response to the gaps in literature, this article examines historically rooted structural conditions that undergird his rise to power, and the tendencies in the political economy of development that he perpetuates under a political rule marked by authoritarian and illiberal practice. Based on an analysis of national development strategies from 1986 to 2017, and key policies regulating production and redistribution that Duterte has championed in his first two years in office, the article shows the consistency of his political economy vision with post-Marcos development strategies, which in turn are anchored on neoliberal economic doctrine. This brings to the fore the central paradox that the paper unpacks: how Duterte has secured power on the back of the development failures of the past three decades, but nevertheless perpetuated the neoliberal economic strategies associated with these failures. This paradox relates to the broader puzzle of the imperviousness of neoliberalism to political transformations, including those wrought by the rising sway of new right populist politics. The central claim of this article is the observed perpetuation of neoliberal economic doctrine alongside authoritarian-illiberal practice is an outcome of secular processes of depoliticisation associated with neoliberalism. In this sense, new right populist politics praxis is as much a legacy of, as it is a reaction to, neoliberalism.

The election as president of Rodrigo Duterte, who openly dismisses democracy and human rights as "principles imposed by the West via modern imperialism" (Heydarian 2018a), represents a marked illiberal turn in Philippine politics in 2016, thirty years after the end of president Ferdinand Marcos' economically debilitating and politically oppressive authoritarian rule[1]. Duterte's election has been cast as a manifestation of a recognisable shift in the conduct of electoral politics, traversing ideological and developmental divides across the world, towards what Putzel (2020:418-419) calls the practice of 'new right populist politics', whereby power is sought and gained by political actors presenting themselves as 'outsiders' who challenge the status quo and promise grand departures from it, whilst also promoting divisive discourses on the poor, minorities, and women, as well as being tolerant of transgressions on individual rights.

In the case of Duterte, the grand departure he promised related to addressing the purported failures of the liberal elites who came before him. In line with his campaign slogan 'change is coming', he vowed to deliver security and order by addressing at all costs the purported rampant problems of drugs and criminality; and to break the stranglehold of the country's capital 'Imperial Manila' on economic and political power. Once in power, he did not balk at deploying illiberal and authoritarian practice to deliver on these campaign promises. Following Glasius (2018), 'authoritarian practice' refers to patterns of action, in an organised social context, that serve to sabotage accountability to people over whom a political actor exerts control. For example, Duterte has translated his campaign promise of deconcentrating power from the

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[1] Ferdinand Marcos was president of the Philippines from 1965 to 1986. He declared Martial Law from 1972 until 1981, using exaggerated threats posed by Communist and Muslim insurgencies as justification. During that period, he ruled by decree, abolishing Congress, closing down media establishments and arresting key opposition figures.

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.geoforum.2021.04.001
Received 11 June 2019; Received in revised form 30 March 2021; Accepted 2 April 2021
Available online 18 April 2021
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national political capital into attacks not just on individual civil liberties, but also on constitutional checks and balance and independent media. Within his first two years in power, a vocal opposition senator was imprisoned[2]; critical media personalities, legally harangued[3]; and the independent-minded chief of the Supreme Court, ousted from office[4]. In light of these, Duterte's bid to deconcentrate power has been translated in the narrowest of senses – the disempowerment of political opposition. Meanwhile, also following Glasius (2018), 'illiberal practice' refers to patterns of same such action that serve to infringe on individual autonomy and dignity. For instance, to deal with drugs and associated criminality, Duterte has led a civil-rights crushing 'war on drugs'. This war is featured by state-supported 'extra-judicial killings' of suspected drug pushers and drug addicts, which thereby render justice without due process. That these 'criminals' worthy of extermination also tend to be poor instantiates the deeply conservative core of illiberal practice under Duterte. (Ramos 2020: 486)

This article puts the spotlight on how Duterte has wielded power during his first three years in office, particularly in the domain of economic governance, which is viewed against patterns in the political economy of development of a longer historical durée. It offers an optic on the Duterte presidency that reveals two dimensions which are not sufficiently examined by extant political studies of his rise to power. First, rather than emphasizing the historical break that Duterte's election ostensibly represents, this article reveals the worrying patterns of historical continuity in the political economy of Philippine development that he enables. Second, rather than emphasizing the conjunctural, the analysis proffers a view of the structural conditions that both presage Duterte's ascent to power, and are in danger of being preserved under his presidency.

Exploring these dimensions in turn reveals the following paradox, which is significant elsewhere today were we find the concurrence of authoritarian and neoliberal praxis: how democratic reversals under the auspices of new right populist politicians have been buttressed by development failures of the past three decades, but coincide with the perpetuation of the neoliberal economic strategies that caused these failures. In the case of the Philippines, the historical disruption embodied by the return of strongman rule is happening alongside the continuation of the post-Marcos development strategies of the last 30 years, which in turn are anchored on neoliberal economic doctrine, defined following Fischer (2019), as "a combination of monetarist, purportedly neutral but often pro-cyclical macroeconomic policy, the trio of privatization, liberalization and deregulation, and attempts to introduce market-type or market-mimicking mechanisms into spaces that operate according to different logics, particularly in the public sector".

The wider analytical contribution of this article pertains to the provision of an explanation to the seeming imperviousness of neoliberalism to contemporary transformations and reversals in democratic practice, such as those that are embodied by the rising sway of new right populist politics. The central claim of this article is that conditions for the currently observed perpetuation of neoliberal economic doctrine alongside authoritarian-illiberal practice have been fostered by the neoliberal project of depoliticisation itself. The argument proceeds from the deployment and conception of 'neoliberalism' as pertaining to not just the doctrinaire pursuit of laissez faire economics, but in terms of the Foucauldian conception of the term as referring to the political project to marketise wider sections of society. The Philippine case thereby shows how the rise of new right populist politics can be seen as a logical outcome of neoliberalism itself rather than just a reaction to it.

The analysis proceeds from a critical review of extant political studies of the Duterte presidency, and is developed through a historical study – covering the past three decades – of structural conditions, as well development strategies and policies that regulate production and redistribution. The structural conditions – observed in terms of indicators of productive transitioning to an industrialised and diversified economy, and redistribution of any gains from periods of economic recovery of the recent decade – are analysed on the basis of economic data on national income accounts, poverty, and inequality, which are all viewed comparatively with those of neighbouring countries in the region. National development strategies from 1986 to 2017 are examined through a survey of: literature on Philippine development planning and economic history since the Marcos period; the actual national development plans of the Duterte administration and those of his predecessor, Benigno Aquino Jr.; and tax and infrastructure development policies that Duterte has championed in his first two years in office.

The analysis is developed in five parts. In the first section, the significance of analysing the concurrence of authoritarianism and neoliberal praxis under the current sway of new right populist politics is discussed. This significance is explained both in terms of how it addresses the limits of preponderant literature providing specific accounts of the return of strongman rule in the Philippines, and contributes to the wider study of new right populist politics. In the following three sections, the empirical dimensions of the analysis of the Philippine case are discussed. In the first of these, the structural conditions before Duterte's ascent to power are analysed, highlighting how assessments of the severe economic downturn that happened under the watch of strongman Marcos have influenced national development planning in the three decades that followed. In the last two of these empirical sections, evidence for the entrenchment of neoliberal economic doctrine in national development policies from 1986 to 2017 is presented. In the concluding section, the insights generated by the analysis of the Philippine case on the symbiosis between authoritarian and neoliberal praxis, and its significance where new populist politics is currently ascendant, are summarised.

1. Authoritarian and neoliberal praxis: why study their concurrence and how

Much has been said about the circumstances that led to the election of Duterte, and with that, the return of strongman rule in the Philippines. A strand of the literature analyses Duterte's election in conjunction with the rise to power of other populist strongmen on the current world historical stage. Here, the election of Duterte is seen as rising out of interactions during this conjuncture between national historico-political dynamics and the fall-out from four decades of neoliberal globalisation. Putzel (2018) argues that Duterte's election in the Philippines is emblematic of the potency of new populist politics, which is driven by: the structural processes of urbanisation and technological advances leading to significant changes in how electoral contests are conducted; and the backlash against the excesses of four decades of the dominance of neoliberalism in the international political arena. Meanwhile, McCoy (2017a, 2017b) also sees the rise of populist leaders like Duterte as being produced by a confluence of global forces and particular local political traditions. In line with Putzel's analysis, he recognises that populist leaders have gained influence by giving voice to public concerns about the costs of the 25 years of globalisation after the Cold War. McCoy (2017a) argues, in addition to this, that Duterte has also been adept at playing upon the rivalry between the US and China to strengthen his international position: announcing during his state visit to China in October 2016 rapprochement with Beijing and separation from Washington, but tilting back to the US after the election of Trump in November 2016. Thus, he is said to have been able to gain freedom of

[2] Leila de Lima was arrested in February 2017 (Villamor, 2017) and is still in prison.

[3] Prominent journalist Maria Ressa was arrested in two separate occasions in 2019 for allegedly violating laws barring foreign ownership of media, and for an alleged internet libel case, respectively (BBC, 2019).

[4] Supreme Court Chief Justice Maria Lourdes Sereno, was ousted from office in May 2018 on grounds that she had failed to fully disclose her personal wealth. (Villamor, 2018)

manoeuvre to maximise concession from the rival superpowers. In terms of national dynamics, McCoy (2017b) highlights the central role of 'performative violence': the use of raw violence in effecting order and, through that, project personal power and authority. He says that Duterte's violent rhetoric finds historical resonance with that of the country's only other strongman president, Ferdinand Marcos, whom Duterte praises and whose preserved body he has deemed fit to be buried in the country's cemetery of heroes.

Another strand of the literature emphasizes the agency of the publics electing Duterte and supporting his politics. Curato (2016) emphasizes that the relationship between populist Duterte and his supporters runs beyond manipulation and demagoguery and that it is negotiated and a product of this public's moral calculations. She sees in the election of Duterte new possibilities for disrupting electoral politics partial to money and political machinery. (Curato 2016, 106) Other strands of literature elaborate on the nature of the discontent felt by Duterte's supportive public. Bello (2017) and Juego (2017) argue that the election of Duterte could be seen as a manifestation of a public holding to account the failure of the 'EDSA liberal democratic republic' – that matrix of institutions established after the popular uprising of 1986 that led to the ouster of Marcos – to deliver on wider scale economic empowerment and wealth redistribution. Heydarian (2018a), in contrast, argues that it is a manifestation of the public's simmering impatience with the limited ways in which liberal democratic institutions have delivered law and order, and effective public services. Garrido (2020) posits that middle and upper-class support for Duterte has been a result of a trajectory of accumulated frustration with the functioning of democracy but also contingent on the discrediting of other presidential contenders and disappointment with his predecessor's administration.

Extant literature has thus far centred on explaining the conditions that led to Duterte's election, and doing so tends to emphasize – though perhaps not entirely by design – the historic break represented by his rise to power, while also drawing attention to this phenomenon as a product of the current historical conjuncture. However, it has done little to sufficiently explain the structural roots and developmental implications of the return of strongman rule in the Philippines.[5] This is the lacuna that this article addresses by analysing the concurrence of authoritarian and neoliberal praxis under Duterte. By filling such a gap in the literature, it also contributes to explaining a broader puzzle made evident during this period of the rising power of new right populists: the endurance of neoliberal praxis in the face of important political transformations and reversals.

In the last three decades since the 1990s, the pursuit and preservation of neoliberal economic doctrine have continued amidst significant changes in political currents related to democratic practice. On one hand, the promotion of this doctrine thrived in the period of ostensible expansion of formal liberal democratic practice following the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989. This was buttressed, from the 1990s to the 2000s, by the ascendance in development policy-speak of the 'good governance agenda' (as described in World Bank 1997, Kaufmann et al 1999 and reviewed critically by Khan 2005; Chang 2003) , which pitches democratisation – including the conduct of free elections, the fight against corruption, and the construction of institutions of accountability – as a precondition for the efficient functioning of market economies, and through that for development. In this period, democratisation was thereby effectively made a natural adjunct of economic liberalisation. On the other hand, its promotion evidently continues in the period of democratic reversal after the Great Financial Crisis of 2008, as practitioners of new right populist politics like Duterte took power across the world on the back of the perceived failures of neoliberalism.

It is of course important to recognise that there are palpable ways that new right populist politicians may be seen as diverging from the neoliberal order. As noted by Putzel (2020: 421), these include not just their tolerance for operating outside the rule of law, but also their privileging of domestic over foreign markets, and their eschewing of the rights agenda associated with the so-called 'mature phase' of neoliberalism. But these divergences evidently do not preclude the continued promotion of the market order, and with this the protection of the interests of capital. For example, Hendrikse (2018) observes that in the 'neoliberal heartlands' in the US and Europe, the rise of populist attacks against liberal democracy – including attacks on checks and balances, on wider societal counterpowers, and on systems of individual civil and human rights – are all happening while the neoliberal infrastructure undergirding global capitalism remains preserved. Hendrikse suggests that illiberal politics effectively functions as a 'toxic protective coating' of neoliberalism in these instances. In India, Ghosh (2020) observes that Modi's 'politics of hatred' coincides with 'unabashedly neoliberal and pro-big capital' policies – with the government managing whatever contradictions there may be disassociating economic outcomes from policies.

A broadened conception of 'neoliberalism' is deployed in this article to help in rendering the above-described puzzle legible. Following Kiely (2018, 2020), 'neoliberalism' is construed as a project to promote the general philosophy of market society through the depoliticisation of its wider sections, and that is inherently reliant on the state to carry it out. But, while reliant on the deployment of state power, the neoliberal project is agnostic to the institutional form that power takes. For example, Kiely (2020) cites German ordo-liberals as pursuing the neoliberal project of depoliticisation in the 1930s, not through the technocratisation of governance as neoliberalism later came to be associated with, but through the promotion of an authoritarian state that is able to overcome particularistic interests and thereby ensure the establishment of a neutral market order. Venugopal (2015) similarly argues that one variant of actually existing neoliberalisms is in its incarnation as a project of authoritarian capital in Chile, with the authoritarian regime of Pinochet waging a war against the labouring poor at the behest of domestic business and agrarian elites. Put in another way, Bruff (2014) argues that neoliberalism entails the mobilisation of institutional power in a variety of ways – including through a state made nondemocratic by its subordination to rules that are deemed necessary for prosperity to be achieved.

Meanwhile, depoliticisation is understood, following Madra and Adaman (2014), as the "naturalisation of economic processes or technocratisation of their governance or both". Kiely (2020) notes that whilst German ordo-liberals of the 1930s pursued neoliberalism through the promotion of the authoritarian state, adherents of the Chicago School of neoliberalism of the 1940s in the US espoused the same through the promotion of technocratisation – emphasizing the costs of state regulation, and championing the eradication of the boundaries between the state, market and society. In this sense, depoliticisation could be argued to underpin what Putzel (2020: 423) sees as the political legacy of neoliberalism: the promotion of an intellectual architecture that construes the realm of the state as a site of individual self-seeking behaviour and prone to corruption, which has thereby fostered cynicism in all forms of public authority.

The above lenses render less quizzical the observed symbiosis between neoliberal and authoritarian-illiberal praxis under the leadership of new right populist politicians. For one, given the vaunted flexibility of the depoliticisation project to institutional forms of state power, there is nothing now inherently surprising about the observed compatibility of strongman rule with neoliberal praxis. More importantly, by fostering cynicism in all forms of public authority, neoliberalism can be understood as creating the conditions not only for new right populist politicians to win votes by pitching themselves as outsiders to the established system of political authority, but also enabling them to focus their platform of purported change on the political uses of state power, whilst turning a blind eye on its uses for structural transformation and

[5] Putzel (2020) and Ramos (2020) are exceptions to this – they examine the implications of populist authoritarian dispensation on the goals of social transformation and inclusion by analysing social policy under Duterte.

economic redistribution.

The next three sections expound on the empirical dimensions of the imperviousness of neoliberalism to political transformations and reversals in the Philippine case.

2. Before Duterte: Structural conditions and the roots of neoliberalism

The development patterns in the Philippines since the fall of Marcos from power in 1986, in the aftermath of the 'EDSA People Power Revolution'[6], suggest the structural conditions that buttress Duterte's rise to power. As shown in Fig. 1, while the Philippines had the second highest per capita income from 1960 right up to 1983, it has been overtaken by Thailand, Malaysia, and Indonesia in the last three decades or so, and never really recovered its place since then. The weak structural foundations of the economy are further exhibited by trajectories of productive transformation that reveal limited scope for mass employment through industrialisation. Like its neighbours in the region, the share of agricultural output in national income in the Philippines has progressively decreased in the last 30 years. However, transformation towards industry and manufacturing has been the least pronounced of the neighbouring countries.[7]

The Philippines has also lagged behind most of its regional neighbours in the tasks of eradicating poverty and improving income inequality. Data from the World Bank (2019c) covering 1981–2017[8] shows that in contrast to Malaysia and Thailand, which had virtually eradicated absolute poverty by the mid-1990s, the Philippines has the highest poverty headcount ratio as of 2015. It is trumped even by Indonesia, which by all indications has had to deal with higher rates of poverty than the Philippines in the 1980s. Moreover, Indonesia and Thailand have been better than the Philippines in seeing to declines in levels of income inequality, particularly from 2000 onwards.[9](World Bank, 2019b) A further reminder that the benefits from the growth episode of the 2010s have not been widely distributed in the Philippines is seen in calculations by Forbes Asia in 2012 (in Keenan 2013), indicating that the increase in collective wealth of the 40 richest Filipino families accounted for about 77 percent of the country's overall increase in GDP in 2010–2011. In contrast to this, Thailand's 40 richest families accounted for only 34 percent of the growth of national income during the same period; in Malaysia, 6 percent. (Agence France-Presse 2013)

The lacklustre structural transformation foreshadowing Duterte's rise to power comes off the 'lost decade for Philippine growth', the 1980s. Just before the EDSA People Power Revolution, the country had suffered its first and deepest to date post-war economic recession. As shown in Fig. 1, the recession of 1984–1985 was the turning point for the Philippines in terms of moribund economic performance. Development strategies pursued in the Philippines in the years following this lost decade of the 1980s have been partly shaped and rationalised by preponderant narratives explaining the economic recession that happened towards the end of Marcosian rule.

On one hand, Marcos-period technocrats highlight the short-term roots of the recession and trace it to external price shocks and conjunctural political crisis. For example, Gerardo Sicat (1984), the chief economic planner during the time of Marcos, focuses on what happened in 1983 to explain the economic downturn that followed. He says that although world commodity prices of the Philippines' traditional exports during that year had already been recovering from the fall seen earlier on in the decade, this had not been enough to improve the resultant dampening of export revenues, which in turn meant that the country's external payments continued to worsen. He says the situation was then exacerbated by the assassination of the leader of political opposition[10], which raised the sceptre of uncertainty about the possibilities for peaceful political succession and led to capital flight of destabilising proportions. The rapid deterioration of both the capital and current accounts led to a widening of the balance of payments deficit, and the Philippines peso depreciated by 54 percent by the end of the year. A 90-day moratorium on external debt payments was declared soon after (Sicat 1984:250), accompanied by a World Bank bail-out loan that came along with requisite macroeconomic and fiscal tightening measures. He also recognises the role played in the crisis by the build-up – beginning a decade before the economic crisis – and servicing of external debts. But he suggests that the debt build-up – both private and public – had been necessary to finance investment projects for economic development, particularly in the aftermath of the world economic recession following the oil price shocks of the 1970s. (Sicat 1984:254) Meanwhile, he recognises the policies associated with structural adjustment: in the first instance, policies of deregulation and liberalisation that began in the 1970s; and later, the aforementioned policies of fiscal constraint and belt-tightening following external debt restructuring in 1983 – imposed 'not inconsequential, but necessary short-term costs'. (Sicat 1984:264)

On the other hand, others are more pronouncedly critical of Marcos' role in this economic downturn, casting the recession as the logical culmination of twenty years of patrimonial plunder, whereby access to the political machinery by privileged cronies was used to accumulate private wealth, absent a coherent set of development strategies. De Dios and Hutchroft (2003) note that while Marcos was merely expanding earlier patterns of patrimonial plunder, he was exceptional in terms of centralising control over the state apparatus and prolonging his ability to do so, after he suspended processes of democratic succession and accountability, and ruled under Martial Law from 1972 to 1981. They say that Martial Law perpetuated important shortcomings of Philippine capitalism, whereby particularistic demands continued to prevail. But they argue that Marcos, unlike past presidents, appropriated a bigger proportion of the state apparatus for his own private ends. Moreover, they argue that given the ready availability of external funds – alluding to the liquidity of international credit markets awash with petro-dollars in the 1970s – it was easier to adopt a strategy of debt-driven growth rather than export-oriented industrialisation (De Dios and Hutchroft 2003:6–8) External debts, which as noted above Sicat benignly characterises as necessary financing for investment projects, had ballooned from US$600 million, at the start of the Marcos' presidency in 1965, to US$26 billion in 1986; by 1983 it had comprised 91 percent of the country's GNP, and 509 percent of export earnings (Tadem 2016). The

[6] Popular demonstrations that happened in the capital city of Manila from February 22 to 25, 1986 leading to the ouster of Marcos. These were acts of civil resistance against perceived regime violence and alleged electoral fraud. EDSA refers to the Epifanio de los Santos Avenue, where the demonstrations took place.

[7] Agricultural output as a share of total gross value added in 2008–2017, is as follows: Philippines, 11.5%; Indonesia, 15.5%; Malaysia, 9.5%; Thailand, 9.2%. Industrial output as a share of total gross value added in the same period is as follows: Philippines, 31.4%; Indonesia, 42.9%; Malaysia, 45.9%; Thailand, 37.7%. Manufacturing output as a share of total gross value added in the same period is as follows: Philippines, 20.7%; Indonesia, 22.3%; Malaysia, 23.1%; Thailand, 28.6%. (World Bank 2019a)

[8] Poverty headcount ratio, at $1.90PPP in selected years between 1981 and 2017 (including the latest year within that period that comparable data was available) is as follows: Malaysia, 1984, 2.9; 1995, 1.8; 2004, 0.4; 2011, 0.1. Thailand, 1981, 19.6; 1992: 6.6; 2002, 1.1; 2013, 0.1. Indonesia, 1984, 71.4; 1993, 58.5; 2003, 22.6; 2017, 6.7. Philippines, 1985, 28.1; 1994, 25.0; 2005, 14.7; 2015, 7.8 (World Bank 2019c)

[9] GINI Index in selected years between 1981 and 2017 (including the latest year with that period that comparable data was available) is as follows: Malaysia, 1984, 48.6; 1995, 48.5; 2004, 46.1; 2015, 41.0. Thailand, 1981, 45.2; 1992, 47.9; 2002, 41.9; 2017, 36.5. Indonesia, 1984, 32.4; 1993, 32.0; 2003, 31.8; 2017, 36.5. Philippines, 1985, 41.0; 1994, 42.9; 2006, 42.9; 2015, 40.1 (World Bank 2019b)

[10] The assassination of Benigno Aquino on August 21, 1983 is widely seen to have triggered waves of political mobilisations that led to EDSA People Power Revolution.

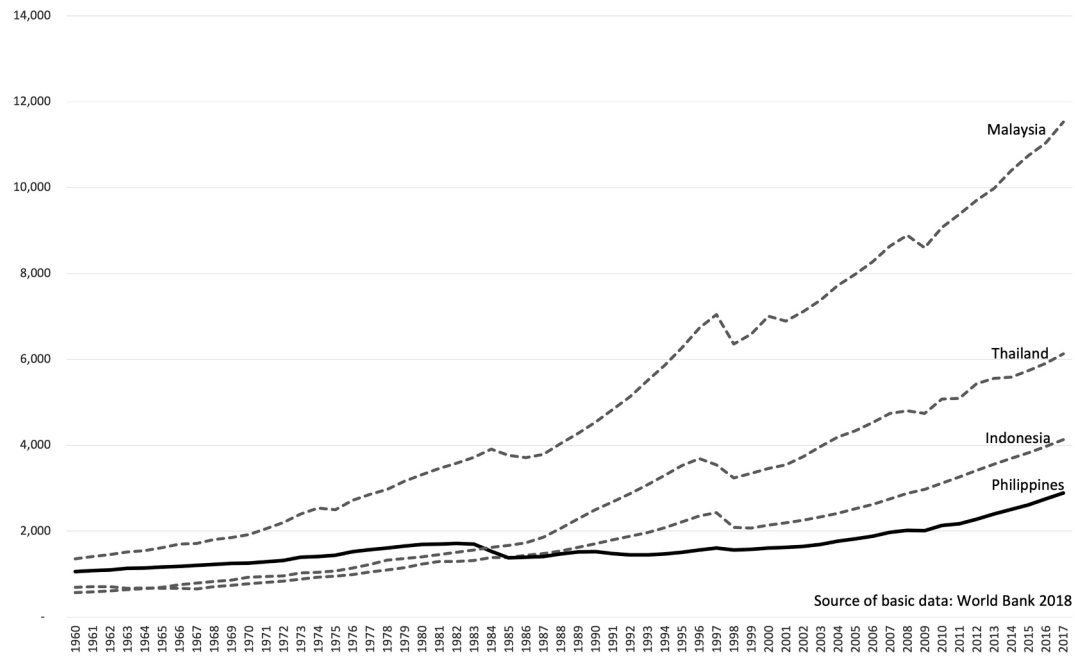

Fig. 1. GDP per capita 1960-2017 (in constant 2010 US$ prices): Selected Southeast Asian Countries. (See above-mentioned references for further information.)

problem is that the debts were used to finance investment projects that have been described as overpriced, mismanaged, not viable to begin with, or made unviable by changes in exchange rate and the international environment. (UPSE 1986 in Tadem 2016) The most iconic example of these is the Bataan Nuclear Power Plant project, which was completed in 1985 and was funded by a loan of US$2 billion. This power plant was never operational, being geographically positioned along earthquake fault lines, but principal and interest debt payments associated with it ballooned to US$22 billion and was only fully paid in 2007.

These contending narratives on the circumstances that brought about the lost decade of the 1980s play an important role in strengthening the foothold of neoliberal economic doctrine in the Philippines. On one hand, the accounts of Marcos period technocrats like Sicat under-emphasize the role of structural adjustment policies in creating the conditions for the economic downturn. On the other hand, analyses that focus on corruption under Marcos as the basis for the economic malaise of the 1980s may have also had the unintended consequence of laying the grounds for the pathologizing of politics and all but the most minimalist of state interventions in the economy, which as the next section shows, deepened in the thirty years that followed.

3. The entrenchment of neoliberalism

Following the fall of Marcos from power, the Philippines saw to a period of democratic transitioning and consolidation. In the face of changing leaders, external shocks, and domestic political upheavals accompanying these political transformations, a historical analysis of national development plans and over-arching policy thrusts reveals the preservation of the core tenets of neoliberal development strategies in economic planning.

In a lot of ways, the institutional path entrenching neoliberal development strategies, began to harden soon after the economic recession of 1984–1985, during the presidency of Corazon Aquino. Widow of the martyred opposition leader whose assassination triggered the national crisis that led to Marcos' downfall, she was swept to power by a broad-ranging coalition that included "politicised military factions, anti-Marcos financial and industrial elite, articulate urban middle class, and non-government organisations from the moderate and radical left" (De Dios and Hutchcroft 2003:9). With factions of the progressive left made part of the new governing coalition, she should have had the greatest chance and compulsion to veer away from the course set in the 1970s by Marcos, and to strengthen the redistributive agenda that had been absent from previous national development plans. However, the 1987–1992 development plan stayed the course in terms of identifying economic liberalisation as the key strategy for attaining sustainable economic growth. Industrial development was to be guided by the principle of comparative advantage and led by agricultural development. The plan did mention poverty alleviation as a major goal for the first time; and agrarian reform was cited as a key strategy for promoting equity and social justice. (Jurado 2003:15-16) But in the end, conflict is said to have emerged between the imperatives of re-arranging property rights to favour historically marginalised populations, as well as those excluded during the time of Marcos, and the desire to restore investor confidence. The latter imperative– compounded by several violent attempts by the military to overthrow her, and fiscal crisis partly brought about by the continuing servicing of onerous debts incurred during the time of Marcos – pushed the Aquino government towards weakening its redistributive agenda. Agrarian reform, the centrepiece redistributive programme was "ultimately undermined by slow and uneven adjudication of cases, government's inability to finance compensation for landlords, and by allowing loopholes in implementation by landlord interest-dominated congress". (De Dios and Hutchcroft 2003:10-12).

Following Aquino, Fidel Ramos oversaw national development strategies under the banner call of 'Philippines 2000′, an economic programme that sought the Philippines' attainment of 'newly-industrialised country' status by turn of the 21st century. The national development plan of 1993–1998 cast 'human development' as the ultimate goal, and identified liberalisation, deregulation, and globalisation as strategies to achieve economic growth and alleviate poverty. (Jurado 2003:17) One difference of Ramos from other presidents is that he wielded the liberalisation agenda as a tool to attack the politics of privilege. He attempted to deconcentrate economic power by introducing competition in key industries like telecommunications, airlines, shipping, and banking. He saw to the privatisation of state corporations, and eliminated most capital controls in a bid to attract foreign investment flows. The 1990s was a period of economic growth, stymied only by the financial crisis that hit the region in 1997. Ramos' anti-oligarchy

rhetoric and the loosening of capital controls was rewarded by the entry of fleet-footed capital, which created stock market and real estate bubbles. The growth episode was therefore not necessarily underpinned by the widening of employment-creating productive capacity.

After Ramos came Joseph Estrada, who was president from 1998 to 2001 – a term that should have lasted six years but was cut short by three. He was forced out of office[11] in 2001, in the wake of massive protests in Manila that came to be known as 'EDSA II,' and the consequent withdrawal of support for his leadership by the military. This happened amidst an impeachment trial in which Estrada was charged to have received pay-off money from illegal gambling operators. In the three years that he was in office, Estrada adopted pro-poor rhetoric, and used the banner call of 'Angat Pilipinas' (Arise, Philippines!) for his national development plans. However, his anti-poverty programme never gained ground; and no significant policy shifts happened under his watch, as he appointed technocrats, who continued to champion the previous administration's liberalisation agenda. (De Dios and Hutchcroft 2003: 20-21) His term was marked by the wide-scale return of presidential access granting benefits to vested interests. He was deemed guilty of plunder by the Philippines anti-corruption court and sentenced to life in prison in 2007 – at this point he had already been detained in an especially appointed government facility for almost seven years. Gloria Macapagal Arroyo, the Vice-President who took his seat after the Supreme Court deemed Estrada resigned from office in 2001, granted him executive clemency and released from detention that same year that the court meted out its judgment.

Arroyo took over from Estrada's shortened presidency in 2001, and having won the presidential elections when she ran in 2004, was in power for a total period covering almost a decade until 2010. The rallying call of the national development plans under her leadership was 'Strong Republic', giving priority to stamping out corruption and improving governance – obviously a response to the institutional tumult of the past administration. The economic core of the development plans was more of the same: articulating a strategy that focuses on growth and human development within the framework of macroeconomic stability, free enterprise, and good governance. (Jurado 2003:17-18) The Philippines saw again a period of economic rebound and growth, driven by growth of agriculture and services and enough to win over business support for her leadership. But given that the circumstances of her ascent to power brought both legal and extra-constitutional challenges to her administration, Arroyo was hobbled by the need to build alliances based on loyalties and political exchange to stay in power. Though she was able to finish her term, she was detained by government on 'hospital arrest' from 2011 to 2016, charged with electoral sabotage by the Commission on Elections, and later on corruption charges. The Supreme Court later released her from hospital arrest in 2016, and dismissed corruption charges against her.

Economic growth without structural transformation and equity continued under the presidency of Benigno Aquino Jr., from 2011 to 2016 despite national development plans during his term setting 'inclusive growth', defined as sustained high growth rates of the type that creates jobs and reduces poverty, as the ultimate goal. (National Economic and Development Authority 2011:19) This goal was to be achieved through a platform of good governance. Continuing the central themes also articulated in national development plans of Arroyo, whose arrest and detention underscore the country's continuing problems with corruption, Aquino ran a presidential campaign using the slogan of 'Daang Matuwid' ('the straight path'). He later converted this into a platform called 'Social Contract with the Filipino People', highlighting his vision of 'transformational leadership' whereby the president was to be the main fighter of corruption; of an economy built on the foundations of rule of law; and of meritocratic civil service. This 'social contract' was used as a guide for all executive issuances, including the national development plans during his presidency. (Baylon 2018:3) Meanwhile, the absence of inclusive growth is diagnosed in the plans as down to inadequate physical infrastructure, weak human development among the poor, growth trajectories that have not created enough jobs, and problems in governance. To address these, the plan's broad strategies are constituted by massive infrastructure development through private–public partnerships; human development with conditional cash transfers and social safety nets identified as having as central a role as the delivery of health and education services, and employment generation principally through support of labour-intensive industries in which the country has comparative advantage. All these strategies are to be supported by a macroeconomic regime of low inflation and sustainable fiscal balances. (National Development Authority 2011:26–30)

In a nutshell, this historical review shows that even as over-arching emphases shifted in ways that were in tune with the evolution of discourses in international development – including for example the attention given to social sectors and poverty alleviation – the development plans of the last 30 years have been essentially programmes of non-interference in the dynamics of market forces, centrally anchored on the pursuit of economic growth. From the 2000s, there also has been a pronounced emphasis on addressing corruption and governance as a means to achieve development. As will be shown in the next section, the core of Duterte's economic policies in the first two years of his administration veers little from this path that the Philippines has stayed true to these last three decades.

4. Neoliberalism as usual under strongman Duterte

The continuity in political economy vision is best exemplified in the very first agenda-point in Duterte's avowed socio-economic agenda[12]: an explicit avowal to continue and maintain the 'current' (i.e., Aquino's) macroeconomic policies, including fiscal, monetary and trade policies. (National Economic and Development Authority, 2017a) Given that the establishment of an economic environment friendly to private investments – affirmed by the upgrading of the country's investment grade by credit rating agencies and steady rise in global competitiveness surveys (Schnabel 2016) – is being cast as among the most important economic legacies of his predecessor Aquino, it is clear that Duterte is keen on assuring capital that despite his forceful promises for change, it's business as usual for business.

In general, there is very little that separates the predecessor Aquino's from Duterte's national development plans, which are organised under the central slogan of 'AmBisyon Natin 2040′ (Our Ambition, Our Vision 2040). The ambition referred to in this slogan relates to the achievement of 'stable, comfortable, and peaceful lives' by Filipinos, which perhaps signals one divergence from plans of the immediate past: the emphasis on the theme of 'security'. But the strategies set for the attainment of this ambition bear familiar strains from previous development plans: being centred around notions of good governance, this time cast in terms of fostering trust in institutions; paying lip service to addressing exclusion, cast in terms of seeking to provide equality of economic opportunities; and all anchored on the quest for economic growth and sound macroeconomic fundamentals (National Economic and Development Authority, 2017b:12).

But beyond the rhetoric on broader issues of good governance and macroeconomic management, among the most pronounced policies governing production and redistribution in the first two years of

[11] The day after the military declared support for the Vice President, Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo, the Supreme Court declared the presidential seat vacant; and Estrada, deemed resigned from office.

[12] Referred to as the '0+10-Socioeconomic Agenda', this is a distillation of the national development plans for 2017 to 2022. The list begins with '0′, peace and order, pitched as the over-arching concern. This is followed by item number '1′, the continuation of 'current' macroeconomic policies etc., as explained in the text that follows above.

Duterte's term of office also indicate a preservation of neoliberal logic consistent with development strategies of the last 30 years. They continue to feature the light hand of the state in shepherding productive expansion and no significant reforms effecting progressive redistribution.

For one, increasing local and foreign direct investment is deemed foremost of strategies for growth in the industrial and service sectors in Duterte's national development plans. To see to the implementation of this strategy, there is the promise to amend the economic provisions in the 1987 constitution that restrict opportunities for foreign ownership of businesses and assets; to strengthen value and supply chains through the adoption of holistic market-driven perspective; and to implement structural reforms to create well-functioning and competitive markets (NEDA 2017b:21–22) To complement the state's regulatory functions, the government promises to provide infrastructure necessary for lowering the cost of trade and production. The government casts the 'Build, Build, Build' campaign, an ambitious infrastructure development programme that involves 75 flagship projects, including six airports, nine railways, three bus rapid transit systems, 32 roads and bridges, four seaports, four energy generation facilities, ten water resource projects, and five flood control facilities (Heydarian, 2018b), as its centrepiece economic policy.

The prominence being given to the Build, Build, Build campaign is most indicative of Duterte's preferred approach to fostering economic growth: addressing infrastructural bottlenecks that are seen to turn away foreign investors due to the costs these impose on production and trade. It was very soon after his election in 2016 that Duterte's economic team identified infrastructure development as one of the ten key socio-economic priorities of his administration. And in his first state of the nation address in 2017, the president reinforced the importance he gives to infrastructure projects, by promising to increase government spending in infrastructure from 5 percent of GDP in 2017 to 7 percent by 2022, and to spend a total of US$ 180 billion on such projects. The commitment in 2017 alone is celebrated by his allies as representing the doubling of average infrastructure spending of governments in the last 50 years (Villar 2019). In the speech, Duterte averred that an infrastructure boom under his watch, unseen since the time of strongman Marcos (Heydarian, 2018b), would usher in the country's 'golden age of infrastructure'. In his ten-point socio-economic agenda, Duterte initially set out to carry on with Aquino's mode of financing infrastructure development, which was through private–public partnerships (PPP) whereby government tapped private firms in the financing of flagship infrastructure projects. However, at the end of Aquino's term, the outgoing president was criticised for his performance in delivering infrastructure – particularly the various delays and ultimate failure in getting off the ground at least 15 of the planned projects (Nonato 2016). One report finds that only one PPP project was fully completed under his term (Cuaresma 2018:104). This mode of financing thus quickly fell out of favour with the Duterte administration, who has since identified official development assistance, loans and domestic resources as the preferred sources of financing for the infrastructure development programme. Data from the National Economic and Development Authority (in Rivas 2018) indicates that more than 73 percent of the planned projects are to be funded by ODA; about 17 percent, by the national budget; and only about 8 percent, through PPP.

However, this pronounced push for the state's role in the provisioning of infrastructure is not indicative of any real deviation from developmental paths the country has been on. As earlier noted, investing in infrastructure was similarly identified as one of priorities of Duterte's predecessor, whose efforts at enforcing this have not been deemed successful. In a lot of ways, the drive to crank up investments in infrastructure is a continuation of where the previous administration left off. Still and all, what is apparent is that under Duterte, the state continues to be ascribed a minimalist role in laying the grounds for productive transformation in the Philippines. Here, the state's role is primarily cast in terms of fostering conditions for market competition and providing public goods such as the necessary infrastructure to attract private investments.

Meanwhile, even the government's key reform to date with greatest potential redistributive impact is intimately linked to the goal of fostering infrastructure-led economic growth. In 2017, Duterte signed into law the legislation that was passed by Congress to reform taxation and meant to primarily generate resources for infrastructure investments. The law simplifies personal income taxation[13]; simplifies and decrease rates of estate and donors' taxation; increases consumption taxes[14]; and earmarks a portion of the expected incremental revenues to fund targeted subsidies for the poor and vulnerable sectors[15]. In a nutshell, Duterte's tax reforms decrease rates of and government revenues from direct taxes, and increases the role of indirect taxation. The cut in direct taxes is principally brought about by the increase in the threshold for those who are exempted from paying income taxes[16], and the lowering of effective tax rates for most of the taxpayers – except those deemed 'super-rich', who face higher tax rates. It is also a consequence of reductions in the rate of donor's and estate taxes, which are impositions on wealth and asset inheritance. Meanwhile, increases in indirect tax take are generated by provisions of the law that lift exemptions of some sectors from value-added tax; increase tax rates imposed on oil products and automobile purchases; and new taxes on sugary beverages. The government argues that the reforms will raise additional tax revenues, 70 percent of which will then be allocated to the government's infrastructure development programme. Some of the regressive impact of the reforms – particularly that which arises as a consequence of increases in consumption taxes – will then be dealt with by income transfers, for which the remaining 30 percent of incremental revenues will be allocated. (STSR 2018:14-15)

Two issues are widely debated in regard to these redistributive reforms: the fiscal impact and the distribution of burden. The government, as could be expected, has estimates suggesting that the fiscal impact of reforms will be positive; the punitive effects, borne by richer segments of the population. The government estimates tax revenue gains will amount to PhP 63 billion in 2018, PhP 104 billion in 2019, and PhP 140 billion in 2020 (Manasan 2018:25). Economists from the Department of Finance expect that the PhP 147 billion-decrease in personal income tax collection in 2018 would be made up for by increases from indirect tax collection. (Department of Finance 2018:62) Meanwhile, in terms of the redistributive question, there are analysts who suggest that the expansion of indirect taxation will be borne by the relatively well-off. For example, increased excise taxes on fuel and automobiles would theoretically be borne by richer households, in as much as these expenditure items constitute a higher proportion of household income of these households. (Sta. Ana, 2018) The government makes the general case that all sections of the population, divided by income decile, stand to benefit from the reforms; and that it would be the 'super-rich' – households earning more than PhP 8 million a year – that will be made worse off from the combined effects of increased top marginal rate of income taxation and aforementioned changes in consumption taxes. The Department of Finance (2018:67) estimates[17] that the first five income deciles of the population, consisting of the subsistence poor, poor, and

[13] To simplify the personal income taxation, the system was shifted from net income to gross income-based taxation.

[14] Reforms broaden base of value-added taxes by eliminating exemptions and zero-rating to direct exporters; increase excise tax on petroleum products and automobiles; impose tax on sugary drinks; and increase excise tax on cigarettes.

[15] These include monthly unconditional cash transfers to targeted poor households, in the amount of PhP2,400 increasing to PhP3,600 for the period of 4 years, as well rice and transport subsidies.

[16] In the old tax schedule, net taxable annual income was PhP10,000; because of the tax reforms, the cut-off is now PhP50,000.

[17] Based on simulations on household spending based on Family Income and Expenditure Survey of 2015; assuming two earners per household. (Department of Finance 2018:67)

near poor, all stand to take a hit from decreased household income as a result of the increase in consumption taxes – but this is expected to be more than offset by the programmed unconditional cash transfers and rice and transport subsidies these sections of the population are targeted to receive. (Department of Finance 2018:67) In a nutshell, the government submits that sections of the population consisting of unskilled, partially skilled and skilled labourers, professional and middle classes would gain the most net benefits, while the poor (pre-transfers) and the super-rich are expected to bear the worst effects. (Punongbayan 2018)

Other analysts question the government's positive prognostications on the fiscal and redistributive impact of the tax reforms. Manasan (2018:25) is critical about the extent to which the tax reforms could be relied upon to finance the government's infrastructure development drive. She says that contrary to government estimates, she expects total tax revenues of the national government to fall by PhP66 billion in 2018 and PhP 33 billion in 2019, and to only rise by PhP 6 billion in 2020. Actual tax revenue collection data by the Bureau of Internal Revenues and Bureau of Customs support these more modest assessments of revenue potential of the tax reform package. Based on this, the government was PhP 88 billion short of income tax collection targets, and PhP 36 billion short of excise and value-added tax revenues in 2018, a year after reforms were legislated. (Manasan 2018:26) Meanwhile, on the question of redistributive consequences of the tax reforms, analysts suggest that they are probably more regressive and poverty-inducing than suggested by government estimates. Castillo et al (2018) estimate the impact of the tax reforms using a computable general equilibrium model and find that even with the offsetting cash transfers, the poor are hurt most by the changes in the tax system; and that reforms could exacerbate poverty by 0.26 percent even with the transfers in place. Manasan (2018) finds that the tax burden resulting from the reforms as a percentage of household income is highest for the poorest decile and declines as income rises. Punongbayan (2018) flags the regressive impact of inflation wrought by the rise in the price of all oil-based products, which are inputs to most production; he says that the excise taxes' impact on general level of prices is thrice on the poor than the rich.

What all these show is that even the best estimates of government suggest that poorer households would bear the burden of the redistributive reforms, particularly the increases in consumption taxes: both in terms of the negative impact of such taxes on their household incomes and on their spending power in the face of generalised inflationary pressures. This makes the effectiveness of compensatory transfers crucial for countermanding the regressive impact of the tax reforms. In the first year of implementation, questions are already being thrown about the reliability of these transfers to arrest the regressive effects of the tax reforms. While tax increases immediately took effect, there were either delays in the implementation[18] or outright non-implementation[19] of the compensatory measures. And if the worst of the estimates prove correct – in terms of weakened revenue generating capacity in the next two–three years (when the compensatory transfers are also promised) and the worsening of welfare of poorer households – Duterte's tax reforms then portend the weakening of state capacity to generate resources for economic transformation and the deepening of the regressive tendencies of the tax system.

In these debates, there is a worrying silence about the fundamental shift concerning redistribution that is happening under Duterte's watch: the lowering of income and wealth taxation. What probably explains this is that reforms to personal income taxation constitutes a reprieve for a larger swathe of the population, including the middle classes, while leaving those earning the minimum wage less unscathed as they are exempted from income taxation, and negatively affecting only the richest households. The Duterte government's ideational predisposition to putting pecuniary resources in the pockets of households to increase their power to consume, rather than in state coffers for redistribution is best encapsulated in one of the ways that the government in legitimising the changes in the income tax system: "more money for the people in terms of lower income taxes" (Department of Finance 2018:4). This in turn actually embeds neoliberal notions about the desirability of keeping to a minimum state intrusion embodied by taxation. The tax reforms are cast as necessary technical fixes meant to simplify the system, and improve collection efficiency but gloss over difficult conversations about the role of taxes in seeing to a more egalitarian distribution of income through redistribution.

5. Conclusion

This article, in contrast to preponderant literature on Duterte, has situated his presidency in relation to the evolution of post-Marcos patterns and policies of economic development, and laid the foundations for a historically rooted understanding of both its political economy foundations and the nature of the developmental trajectory it is effectively fostering. It put a spotlight on the relevant structural conditions that contextualise his ascent to power, showing that the three decades portending the rise of Duterte are marked by two things. First, viewed from a regional perspective, Philippines exhibited lacklustre economic performance – in terms of seeing to the vision of productive transformation and progressive redistribution – and is still struggling to get back to the position it was in in terms of per capita income shares in 1960. Second, this economic performance is on the back of an unmitigated adherence to neoliberal development strategies that have been ideationally bolstered by assessments of what went wrong during the time of Marcos, particularly the economic crisis of 1983, which is the point in history when the Philippines suffered from it most severe post-World War II economic downturn. These assessments underestimate the role of policies of structural adjustment, liberalisation and deregulation, which actually were first embraced during the time of Marcos and soon before said economic crisis, and have had the effect of pathologising all but the most minimal of state interventions. What followed the crisis was thirty years of the persistent adherence to neoliberal logic, evident in the development strategies and policy thrusts articulated in the national development plans of all presidents following Marcos. Much has been said about the failure of import substitution and protectionism of the 1950s and 1960s in the Philippines, and yet economic growth was more robust during that period than these 30 years of embrace of neoliberalism. The great irony is that these neoliberal development strategies created the very conditions – inequality and lack of structural transformation – that bred the dissatisfaction that strongman Duterte capitalised on in his campaign.

Meanwhile, Duterte stays true to the development trajectory of the past thirty years. Parallel to the deployment of authoritarian and illiberal practice to deliver security and weaken political opposition, he established an economic programme that bears no grand departures from neoliberal economic doctrine, instead even serving its most conservative impulses in terms of income redistribution. His key policies are centred on the build-up of state-provided infrastructure in the hope of fostering private investment-led development, and markedly regressive turn in taxation policies. Duterte effectively disassociated his platform for change, enacted through strongman rule, from any significant economic reforms.

The historical entrenchment of neoliberalism since the fall of Marcos can be seen as creating the very conditions that foster the symbiosis between authoritarian and neoliberal praxis under new right populist Duterte. The secular process of depoliticisation, by feeding on and further fostering cynicism in public authority that first emerged in the 1980s, had the effect of casting use of state power as a source of

[18] Unconditional cash transfers were implemented in March 2018, a few months after the reforms took effect; fuel voucher programme started much later. (Manasan 2018:27)

[19] Transport subsidies have not been distributed because implementing mechanisms for fare discounts for minimum wage earners, unemployed and the poorest 50% of the population, are yet to be designed. (Manasan 2017:27).

development failure, and turning a blind eye to the complicity of neoliberal economic policies to this failure. A space was thus created for Duterte to brandish governance reforms – in particular, the promises of enforcing order and deconcentrating power from 'imperial Manila', delivered through strongman tactics – as solutions to the touted developmental failures of liberal elites and their EDSA republic, and left him free to continue with the core of the economic strategies that have historically buttressed the same failures.

The Philippine case thereby lends to an understanding of how the current wave of new populist politics – including the authoritarian practices associated with it – has been enabled as a logical outcome of the neoliberal project of depoliticization, as much as it is a reaction, as suggested in extant literature, to the failures associated with neoliberal economic doctrine. In developmental terms, the legacy of and the reaction to three decades of neoliberal trajectories in the Philippines turns out to come in the same form: a commitment to economic expansion as a central developmental objective, without putting forward meaningful mechanisms for redistribution. Therein lies the irony, therein lies the tragedy of the return of strongman rule in the Philippines.

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